

# Marsanes

**Codex Reference:** X,1

**Translated by:** Birger A. Pearson

**Source:** Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 460ff.

## Editor's Introduction

Codex X is extant only in fragments representing considerably less than half of its original content. Codices X and XII are the two Nag Hammadi manuscripts which have suffered the most loss. But, unlike Codex XII, the fragments of Codex X represent literature that is previously unknown; that is to say, there does not exist any other extant copy of the tractate(s) contained in it. We do not even know how large Codex X originally was, for the 68 inscribed pages to which the extant fragments are assigned represent an absolute minimum; the original codex could very easily have consisted of over 90 inscribed pages.

We do not know for sure that Codex X contained only one tractate, though what can be determined of the content of the extant fragments suggests that this is the case. Letter-traces of a tractate title, with decorations, occur on a small fragment of the last inscribed page (68). The proper name "Marsanes" has been restored from these letter-traces; hence the title *Marsanes*.

Marsanes is the name of a gnostic prophet known from two other sources: the untitled tractate found in the Bruce Codex names Marsanes and Nikotheos as "perfect men" who had seen visions of a divine being called "the triple-powered one," an emanation of the supreme Father (Cod. Bruc. Untitled, ch. 7). Epiphanius of Salamis mentions among the prophets honored by the "Archontic" Gnostics "a certain Martiades and Marsianos, who had been snatched up into the heavens and had come down after three days" (Haer. 40.7.6). ("Marsianos" is simply a Greek variant of "Marsanes.") It is quite possible that the author of the Bruce Codex tractate had access to *Marsanes*, and our tractate may also have circulated among the "Archontics" discussed by Epiphanius.

In terms of genre, our tractate is an apocalypse, specifically an "apocalypse of Marsanes." "Marsanes" may be a name adopted by the gnostic author (mar means "master" in Syriac). Alternatively, an anonymous author is attributing his writing to a well-known gnostic prophet. In either case, the text contains purported revelations and reports of visionary experiences. There are also passages of a paraenetic character with which the author exhorts and encourages his readers. The text is addressed to members of a gnostic community who have already been initiated (see e.g., 2,19-21; 3,4-9).

The third-century Neoplatonist philosopher, Porphyry, in a biography of his great teacher, Plotinus, refers to certain "sectarians who had abandoned the ancient philosophy" (i.e. Platonism). These sectarians were Gnostics, with whom members of Plotinus' school had come in contact. Porphyry reports that these people "produced apocalypses of Zoroaster and Zostrianos and Nikotheos and Allogenes and Messos and others of this sort" (Vit. Plot. 16). Two of the apocalypses referred to by Porphyry are now available to us in Coptic versions in the Nag

Hammadi corpus: *Zostrianos* (VIII,7) and *Allogenes* (XI,3). *Marsanes*, in terms of its content, is very closely related to these two tractates.

Too much of our tractate is now lost to allow us to give a full account of its content, or even to outline its structure. The first ten pages are relatively intact, however. This part of the tractate contains material relating to a gnostic ascent experience, and includes a discussion of the various levels of reality, symbolically referred to as “seals.” These levels range from the “worldly” and “material,” characterized by corporeal existence (2,16-21), to the realms of the invisible Three-Powered One, the Non-being Spirit, and the unknown Silent One (4,12-23).

The next-best preserved section is from the middle of the codex (pp. 24-42), and contains material on the mystical meaning of the letters of the alphabet and their relation both to the human soul and to the names of the gods and angels of the zodiacal realm and the other spheres of the heavens.

The material at the end of the codex is extremely fragmentary, but there are indications of visionary experiences and a reference to heavenly intermediaries who “spoke like the angels” (63,4). One of these is mentioned by name: Gamaliel (64,19), an angel who appears in a number of Sethian Gnostic sources, including *Melchizedek* (IX,7:5,18). This part of the tractate also includes references to a kind of baptismal ceremony (55,20; 66,1-5). The tractate ends with a word of encouragement to “those who will know [him]” (68,17, probably referring to the supreme Father; cf. 1,11-25).

*Marsanes* has been classified as a Sethian writing, on the basis of features in it which relate to the Sethian Gnostic system (as delineated especially by Hans-Martin Schenke). Seth is nowhere mentioned in the extant fragments, but the revelatory role assigned to Marsanes in this tractate makes it possible for us to see in him an avatar of Seth the savior.

There are no hints in our tractate of any Christian elements or influences, and such items of Jewish origin as are reflected must be assigned to its prehistory, i.e., to the Sethian Gnostic system lying behind the text.

*Marsanes* is one of the Sethian Gnostic tractates in the Nag Hammadi corpus that have been profoundly influenced by Platonist philosophy. The others are *The Three Steles of Seth* (VII,5), *Zostrianos* (VIII,7), and *Allogenes* (XI,5). In fact, both in terms of its metaphysics and its ritual references, *Marsanes* represents a kind of Platonism which coheres well with that of the Syrian Neoplatonist philosopher, Iamblichus of Chalcis (ca. 250-325 C.E.). For *Marsanes*, as for Iamblichus, matter is not evil; indeed, it is capable of salvation (see esp. 5,14-26). Here we see a definite attenuation of the radical dualism characteristic of earlier gnostic texts. For *Marsanes*, as for Iamblichus, the descent of the soul into matter is not regarded as a fall but as a demiurgic function, a doctrine based on Plato’s discussion of the soul and its descent in the *Timaeus* (41a-42b). In *Marsanes*, the descent of a figure called “the Self-begotten One” (Autogenes) represents symbolically the descending soul in its demiurgic function (5,27-6,16). Similar ideas are expressed in Iamblichus’ famous treatise, *On the Mysteries of Egypt* (*De mysteriis* VIII.3).

In terms of its ritual allusions, *Marsanes* is comparable to that variety of late Platonism in which theurgy was cultivated. Theurgy (*theourgia*: “the works [*erga*] of the gods [*theoi*]”) is religious ritual whose chief aim is to assist the human soul in its reascent. The Chaldaean Oracles, a second-century collection of revelatory poetry, is the classic authority for theurgy, but Iamblichus is

probably the greatest exponent and theorist of theurgy among the philosophers. Study of his great work on religious ritual (*De mysteriis*, referred to above) opens up some interesting possibilities for understanding the enigmatic ritual allusions in *Marsanes*. One can thus view *Marsanes* as a text in which gnostic theurgy plays a crucial role.

Examples of *Marsanes*' preoccupation with ritual include the material on the "thirteen seals" (2,12-4,23), which is probably related to a gnostic ritual of ascent. (Cf. *Steles Seth*, which contains prayers and invocations used in such a ritual.) The material on the letters of the alphabet and the nomenclature of the gods and the angels (pp. 19-40) also is related to the ascent ritual, and probably involves ritual chant and special instructions expected to assist the soul in its ascent. An enigmatic reference to "wax images" and "emerald likenesses" (35,1-3) reminds us of Iamblichus' discussion of the use of stones, plants, etc., in theurgic ritual (*De mysteriis* V.23). Even the baptismal references already mentioned (55,20; 66,1-5) could be understood in association with an ascent ritual. (This is probably the case with the references to baptism in *Zostrianos*; see e.g., VIII 5,14-7,22.)

The tractate *Marsanes* was probably written sometime in the third century. There are strong indications of a Syrian background for its gnostic author, but this person could have been active in any number of places in the Mediterranean world, such as Rome or Egypt, though Syria is probably the best guess. From there the original Greek version would have been brought to Egypt and translated into Coptic.